Outlook troubleshooting: not syncing, crashing, password prompts

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Summary

This article guides users and service-desk agents through common Outlook issues such as not syncing, frequent crashes, disconnected status, search failures, and repeated password prompts. It provides quick checks, a self-help troubleshooting flow, agent-focused diagnostic steps, and verification steps to confirm resolution.

Symptoms

- Outlook status bar shows "Disconnected" or "Trying to connect..."
- Send/receive error 0x800CCC0F or 0x8004010F
- Outlook stops responding with message "Outlook has stopped working"
- Repeated credential dialog asking for username/password even after correct entry
- Search returns no results or displays "Indexing incomplete"
- Calendar items not updating

Common causes

- Corrupted Outlook profile or OST file
- Faulty COM add-in interfering with Outlook startup
- Outlook search index corruption or incomplete indexing
- Network connectivity issues (VPN, Wi-Fi, or DNS) preventing connection to Exchange Online
- Expired or locked-out password, or MFA token failure
- Large OST size causing performance issues
- Outdated Outlook client missing recent updates

Preliminary Checks

Before diving into deeper troubleshooting, verify basic connectivity and account status. Ensure the device is connected to the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi (or VPN if remote) and that you can access other Microsoft 365 services like Teams or OneDrive. Confirm that your password has not expired and that you are not locked out (check via the self-service password reset portal). If you see a generic "Disconnected" status, try toggling airplane mode or reconnecting to VPN.

Self-Help Procedure (User)

Follow these steps to resolve most Outlook sync, crash, and password-prompt issues. Perform each step in order and test Outlook after each one before proceeding to the next.

1. 1. Close Outlook completely (right-click the Outlook icon in the taskbar and choose Quit).
2. 2. Start Outlook in safe mode: hold Ctrl while launching Outlook, or run outlook.exe /safe. If Outlook opens without crashing, a COM add-in is likely the cause.
3. 3. Disable all COM add-ins: File -> Options -> Add-Ins -> Manage COM Add-ins -> Go... -> uncheck all items, then OK. Restart Outlook normally and test.
4. 4. If the problem persists, rebuild your Outlook profile: Control Panel -> Mail (Microsoft Outlook) -> Show Profiles -> Add... create a new profile (e.g., "Acme_Test"), set it as default, start Outlook and let it autoconfigure using your corporate credentials.
5. 5. After the new profile downloads your mailbox, verify that email sync works. If successful, you can migrate data from the old OST by copying the .ost file to the new profile location or using Import/Export.
6. 6. Repair the search index: File -> Options -> Search -> Indexing Options -> Advanced -> Rebuild. Allow the rebuild to finish (may take several minutes to an hour depending on mailbox size).
7. 7. Once indexing completes, test Outlook search and send/receive to confirm normal operation.

Service Desk Agent Procedure

Agents should use this structured approach when a user reports Outlook not syncing, crashing, or prompting for

credentials. Collect necessary information, perform remote diagnostics, and apply fixes while documenting each step.

1. 1. Create a ticket and capture the exact symptom(s), any error messages, Outlook version (File -> Office Account -> About Outlook), and whether the issue occurs on-site, remote, or both.
2. 2. Verify the user's network connection: confirm VPN connectivity (GlobalProtect) or ACME-Corp Wi-Fi authentication; ask the user to ping outlook.office365.com and note any packet loss.
3. 3. Check account status in Entra ID: look for expired password, lockout, or MFA registration issues; if needed, trigger a temporary access pass via IAM.
4. 4. Ask the user to start Outlook in safe mode (Ctrl + click). If Outlook works, proceed to disable COM add-ins as described in the self-help steps.
5. 5. If safe mode does not help, remotely run the Microsoft Support and Recovery Assistant (SaRA) for Outlook diagnostics; SaRA will detect profile corruption, OST size, and search index problems.
6. 6. If SaRA recommends a profile rebuild, guide the user through creating a new Outlook profile (Control Panel -> Mail) and set it as default. Monitor the initial sync for completion.
7. 7. After profile rebuild, run the Search Index rebuild via Outlook options or via the command line: `OUTLOOK.EXE /CLEANFREEBUSY` (if needed) and `OUTLOOK.EXE /RESETFOLDERS`.
8. 8. Confirm that email flow, calendar updates, and search are functioning. Close the ticket with resolution notes and request user feedback.

Verification and Closure

After applying any fix, verify that Outlook is functioning correctly before closing the ticket. This ensures the issue is truly resolved and reduces repeat contacts.

When to escalate

If the user continues to experience Outlook sync failures, crashes, or password prompts after completing the self-help and agent procedures (including profile rebuild and search index reindex), escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration L2 team. Provide the following details in the escalation ticket: Outlook version and build number, exact error codes or crash dump IDs, SaRA log files, network trace (Netsh trace or Wireshark capture) showing connectivity to outlook.office365.com, Entra ID sign-in logs showing authentication failures, and a screenshot of the Outlook status bar. If the issue appears to be server-side (e.g., widespread mailbox sync failures), also copy the Exchange Online service health dashboard and consider involving the Identity & Access Management team for authentication-related problems.

Keywords: Outlook not syncing, Outlook crashing, Outlook disconnected, Outlook password prompt, Outlook search not working, rebuild Outlook profile, disable COM add-in, repair search index, Outlook troubleshooting, email not arriving